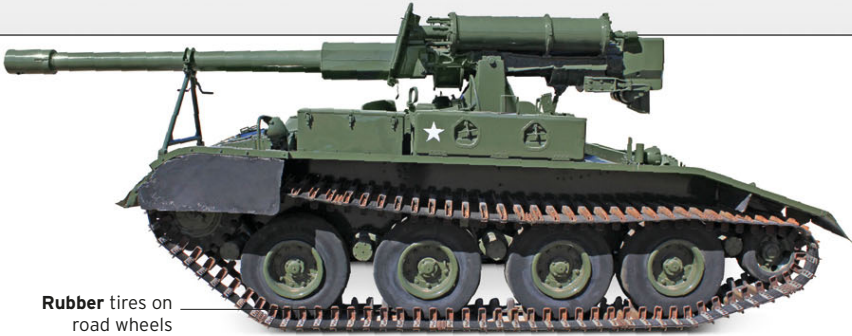


Tank Destroyers

Tracked tank destroyers as used in World War II became less common as the Cold War progressed. By the 1970s, the development of lightweight antitank missiles meant that a heavy, gun-armed vehicle was no longer needed to destroy a tank. Many countries adapted their standard Armored Personnel Carriers (APCs) for the job. Some countries retained the gun-armed vehicles for specific conditions such as close support to infantry or airborne forces, where the ability to fire high-explosive shells remained important.



△	M56 Scorpion
Date	1953
Country	US
Weight	8 tons (7.2 tonnes)
Engine	Continental A6I-402-5 gasoline, 200 hp
Armament	Main 90 mm M54 L/53 rifled gun

Unarmored except for a gun shield, the lightweight Scorpion was designed to be airdropped. Unusually, the road wheels had rubber tires. It saw limited use in Vietnam, with 325 built. Its light weight meant that the gun's recoil was strong enough to lift the front wheels off the ground.



△	Charioteer
Date	1954
Country	UK
Weight	34.7 tons (31.5 tonnes)
Engine	Rolls-Royce Meteor Mark IB gasoline, 600 hp
Main armament	QF 20-pounder gun

An attempt to quickly field more vehicles armed with the highly capable 20-pounder gun, the Charioteer was based on the wartime Cromwell hull. The large gun required a large turret, which was very lightly armored to keep the weight down. A total of 442 Charioteers were built, with almost half being exported.

▷	M50 Ontos
Date	1955
Country	USA
Weight	9.5 tons (8.6 tonnes)
Engine	General Motors Model 302 gasoline, 145 hp
Main armament	6 x 106 mm M40A1 recoilless rifles

Originally intended for US airborne forces, the Ontos was instead adopted by the Marine Corps. In Vietnam, it was used to support infantry. Although its ammunition capacity was limited and the crew had to dismount to reload, its mobility made it popular and its heavy firepower proved invaluable in the urban combat in Hue in 1968.



▷	Saladin
Date	1958
Country	UK
Weight	12.4 tons (11.3 tonnes)
Engine	Rolls-Royce B80 Mark 6A gasoline, 160 hp
Main armament	76 mm L5A1 rifled gun

Designed to replace the wartime Daimler and AEC armored cars, the Saladin had heavier firepower and six-wheel drive, giving it excellent cross-country mobility. It was developed alongside the Saracen (see pp.180-81), with which it shared many components. Highly successful, almost 1,200 Saladins were built. It was exported to more than 20 countries, and saw combat with several, including Oman and Kuwait.